Eric Wetzel

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Summary

Senior executive with 30 years of experience in crisis, litigation, and political communications. Former agency vice president who led accounts for Fortune 500 companies, gubernatorial candidates, and large legal teams. Expertise in media relations and storytelling with hands-on skills in AI-augmented video production, search engine optimization, generative engine optimization, graphic design, and social media marketing. Holds a certificate in data analytics and visualization from the McCombs School of Business at the University of Texas at Austin.

Core Skills

Crisis management, media relations, public affairs, writing and storytelling, leadership of distributed teams, change management, adaptability, creativity, digital fluency

Experience

Communications Director | Council Member Marc Duchen | 4/2025 – Present

- Lead communications, media relations, and digital marketing for Austin's District 10 office
- Prepare the council member for public appearances and interviews
- Produce speeches, talking points, short-form video, and other promotional content
- Cultivate relationships with dozens of news reporters and producers, with coverage of the council member in more than 80 stories to date
- Coordinate efforts with public information staff across City of Austin departments

Founder and Principal | Wetzel & Company | 12/2016 – Present

- Advise private companies, nonprofits, law firms, and political candidates on strategic communications, content marketing, and fundraising
- Lead distributed teams of web and graphic designers, app developers, data providers, videographers, and SEO/GEO specialists
- Served as senior communications advisor to Texas Attorney General candidate Justin Nelson
- Mapped customer experience for North America's largest credential-evaluation service
- Earned first-place search rankings for personal injury law firms

Vice President of Communications | Shipley & Associates, Inc. | 8/2012 – 12/2016

- Led media relations and opposition research teams at a prominent crisis management agency
- Managed accounts for Fortune Global 50 and Fortune 500 companies, gubernatorial candidates, large legal teams, trade associations, and the nation's ninth-largest political donor
- Media spokesperson who earned positive coverage in The New York Times, The Wall Street Journal, The Washington Post, CNN, USA Today, Bloomberg, Politico, HuffPost, and others

Communications Director | Shipley & Associates, Inc. | 8/2004 – 8/2012

- Placed hundreds of media stories for a technology firm engaged in litigation with 70 major financial institutions, helping drive more than $500 million in verdicts and settlements
- Wrote proposals that won client contracts worth hundreds of thousands of dollars
- Produced annual reports and managed grantee relations for a $350 million foundation

Senior Editor | West Egg Communications, Inc. | 11/1997 – 10/2003

- Served as one of the founding editors of Book magazine, nominated for the National Magazine Award in Fiction by the American Society of Magazine Editors
- Helped grow its circulation to 1.3 million and guide it through its acquisition by Barnes & Noble Booksellers
- Managed a team of 20 staffers and freelance writers
- Interviewed bestselling authors and produced news stories, profiles, and features

Technical Proficiencies

- **Basic Tools**
  Microsoft Word, Microsoft Excel, Microsoft PowerPoint, Microsoft Teams, Microsoft Outlook, Google Docs, Google Sheets, Slack, Notion
- **Email Marketing and Media Outreach**
  Mailchimp, Mailjet, Action Network, GetResponse, Cision, Muck Rack, Prowly
- **AI Design and Content Marketing**
  Claude, ChatGPT, Higgsfield, Runway, Gemini, Affinity, Seedance, Canva, CapCut, Instagram Edits
- **Web Design and Site Maintenance**
  WordPress, Hypertext Markup Language (HTML), Cascading Style Sheets (CSS), JavaScript, Bootstrap, AJAX, Flask
- **Data Visualization**
  Tableau, Plotly, Matplotlib, Leaflet, D3.js
- **Programming, Web Scraping, and Data Cleaning**
  Python, Pandas, NumPy, SciPy, Visual Basic for Applications (VBA), Beautiful Soup, Selenium
- **Database Management**
  Structured Query Language (SQL), PostgreSQL, SQLite, MongoDB
- **Machine Learning**
  Multiple Linear Regression, Logistic Regression, Random Forests, Neural Networks, TensorFlow, K-Means Clustering, scikit-learn

Education

Bachelor of Arts in English, Trinity University | San Antonio, Texas

Senior Seminars, St. John's College, University of Oxford | Oxford, England

Professional Certifications

Professional Certificate in Data Analytics and Visualization | McCombs School of Business at the University of Texas at Austin

Board Memberships

Board of Directors | Austin Free Press | 1/2019 – 8/2023

Board of Directors | Austin Bat Cave | 1/2012 – 12/2021

Advisory Council | School of Information at the University of Texas at Austin | 9/2009 – 5/2010